Welcome to East Detroit

Reading 1 of 4: The city, its people and its neighborhoods in 2030

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Real, invented and undecided

East Detroit is a fictional consolidated city and county in Colorado, east of Denver International Airport. The land is real; the city, its statistics, neighborhoods and institutions are invented.

All six documents use three labels:

- **REAL REFERENCE:** a real place, law, organization or published figure. Sources are at the end of each document.
- **SCENARIO:** invented by the course. Treat it as true in the exercise.
- **OPEN:** not yet decided by the class.

Never present SCENARIO figures as real Census data or Colorado law.

The city in 2030

East Detroit grows like metropolitan Phoenix: fast housing growth, master-planned districts, warehousing and logistics, jobs before public facilities, old settlements meeting new development, and uneven benefits. The course starts in 2030; take the city's size as given.

Table 1. East Detroit at a glance

Item	East Detroit in 2030 (SCENARIO)
Official name	City and County of East Detroit, Colorado
Population	382,417
Occupied households	155,800
Residents in group quarters	3,823
How the population is modeled	155,800 households × 2.43 residents + 3,823 in group quarters = 382,417
Study area	About 115.4 square miles, unsurveyed
Built-up area	About 25 square miles, averaging 15,297 people per square mile
Neighborhoods	20 provisional neighborhoods in 5 planning regions

Most of the study area is employment land, farmland, aviation protection zones, infrastructure or open land. Assume the constitutional and legislative steps creating the city-county are done. Its charter design, intergovernmental agreements, service platform and administrative structure are OPEN.

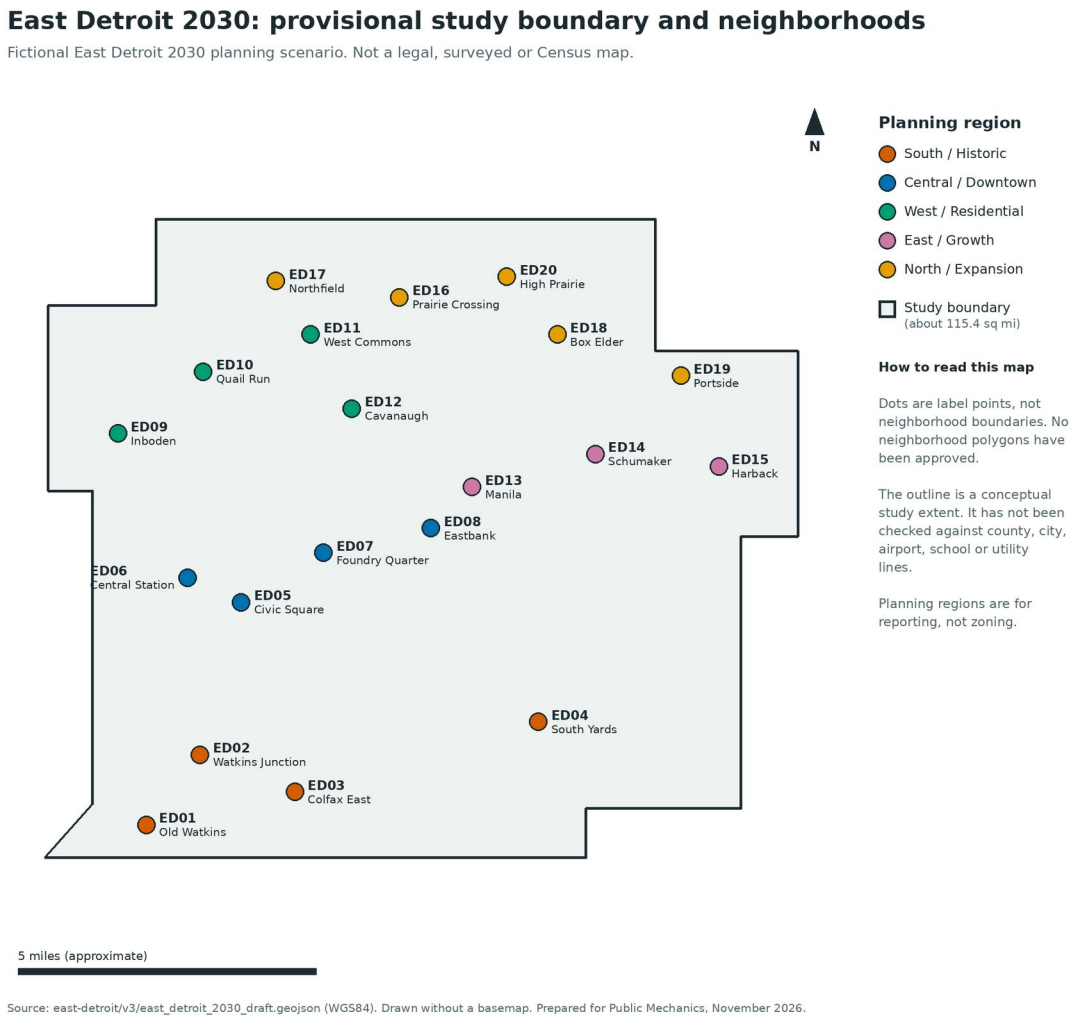


Figure 1. Provisional study boundary and the 20 neighborhood label points, colored by planning region. Dots mark names, not approved boundaries. The outline is unchecked against real county, city, airport, school or utility lines.

Where the city sits

REAL REFERENCE: East Detroit surrounds Watkins, the Colorado Air and Space Port (KCFO), Interstate 70, the Union Pacific rail corridor, Colfax Avenue and Box Elder Creek, with Denver International Airport to the west. The main postal code is Watkins 80137; nearby real codes may appear on maps. The course has created no new ZIP codes. A 2030 postal scheme is OPEN.

Adams County's *Colorado Air and Space Port Subarea Plan* covers 48 square miles bounded by I-70, Hudson Road, E. 72nd Avenue and Harback Road: 21,079 acres of unincorporated Adams County, 9,738 in Aurora and 375 in Bennett. It finds water and wastewater gaps and land-use conflicts near the airport. The fictional city has not solved them.

SCENARIO: East Detroit's study area contains that planning area and extends north and east, leaving room for a credible city without housing around the runway. Watkins remains the historic southeastern gateway.

The real airfield, runway protection zones, stormwater channels, major roads and county and municipal lines limit building. The 2030 transit hubs, light and heavy rail, venue sites, district names and service locations are invented or proposed.

Who lives in East Detroit

Table 2 is SCENARIO planning assumptions. Totals are in Table 1.

Table 2. Fictional socioeconomic profile of East Detroit, 2030

Indicator	East Detroit 2030
Households that rent	53.6%
Median household income, in 2024 dollars	$88,430
People below the poverty line	12.8%
Residents under 18	22.6%
Residents 65 and older	11.6%
Foreign-born residents	18.4%
Residents speaking another language at home	29.6%
Adults with a disability or long-term functional limitation	12.8%
People without health insurance	10.6%
Renters paying at least 30% of income for housing	49.8%
Median gross rent, in 2024 dollars	$1,865 per month
Non-Hispanic White	37.4%
Hispanic or Latino, any race	33.2%
Non-Hispanic Black	13.5%
Non-Hispanic Asian	7.8%
Non-Hispanic Indigenous	1.2%
Other or multiracial, non-Hispanic	6.9%

The race and ethnicity categories add to 100% so the simulation can treat them as separate groups; Census tables handle Hispanic origin differently. Check them against a real classification standard before building household-level data. Never base eligibility on them.

REAL REFERENCE: the scale comes from Adams County. Census QuickFacts, 2020–2024:

- median household income: $94,571 in 2024 dollars
- median gross rent: $1,781
- people in poverty: about 9.8%
- owner-occupied housing: 68.6%
- Hispanic or Latino residents: 43.7%

July 2025 estimate: 554,668 residents.

The real Watkins census-designated place has only 847 residents and a median household income of about $158,173 (2020–2024 American Community Survey). Estimates for so small an area are uncertain.

East Detroit is deliberately harder than Adams County: lower median income, higher rent, more poverty and far more renters.

The twenty neighborhoods

Neighborhoods are communities, not zoning districts; zoning is set separately. Names are provisional. Some come from local streets and landscape (Watkins, Inboden, Quail Run, Cavanaugh, Manila, Schumaker, Harback, Box Elder); others are new (Foundry Quarter, Civic Square, Central Station). Table 3 figures are SCENARIO; propose changes through the class decision record.

Table 3. Neighborhood figures, 2030. Incomes are in 2024 dollars, comparable with the 2020–2024 American Community Survey. Rent-burdened renters pay at least 30% of income for housing.

ID	Neighborhood	Population	Households	Median household income	Renters	Rent-burdened renters
ED01	Old Watkins	10,158	4,180	$103,200	38%	35%
ED02	Watkins Junction	20,908	8,604	$71,600	66%	52%
ED03	Colfax East	18,289	7,526	$58,900	73%	61%
ED04	South Yards	12,271	5,050	$62,100	77%	58%
ED05	Civic Square	26,418	10,505	$92,400	62%	46%
ED06	Central Station	28,405	11,311	$89,700	75%	55%
ED07	Foundry Quarter	25,070	10,177	$74,500	71%	54%
ED08	Eastbank	21,115	8,615	$119,300	47%	37%

ID	Neighborhood	Population	Households	Median household income	Renters	Rent-burdened renters
ED09	Inboden	15,507	6,381	$126,400	33%	28%
ED10	Quail Run	15,651	6,441	$95,600	46%	40%
ED11	West Commons	22,520	9,267	$84,700	52%	45%
ED12	Cavanaugh	16,726	6,883	$78,100	60%	52%
ED13	Manila	24,790	10,058	$112,600	39%	35%
ED14	Schumaker	17,407	7,163	$97,700	45%	43%
ED15	Harback	11,442	4,709	$86,500	53%	49%
ED16	Prairie Crossing	22,663	9,162	$107,900	43%	36%
ED17	Northfield	21,787	8,834	$134,800	29%	30%
ED18	Box Elder	18,676	7,686	$66,800	69%	58%
ED19	Portside	13,690	5,460	$76,700	62%	55%
ED20	High Prairie	18,924	7,788	$151,200	26%	25%

Don't average rows for citywide figures. The citywide median income was set separately, medians do not average, and renter and rent-burden shares need household weighting. Checking citywide figures takes household-level synthetic data.

What each neighborhood is like

South / Historic

- **Old Watkins (ED01):** old village; small businesses, farm families, aging owners and renters.
- **Watkins Junction (ED02):** rail-line mixed housing; service workers, newly arrived families.
- **Colfax East (ED03):** older commercial corridor; cheaper apartments, high turnover.
- **South Yards (ED04):** industrial jobs, truck traffic, housing near worksites, pollution worries.

Central / Downtown

- **Civic Square (ED05):** civic center ringed by mixed-income midrise housing.
- **Central Station (ED06):** main transfer station; dense rentals, night economy.
- **Foundry Quarter (ED07):** old production sites now offices and fairly affordable family flats.
- **Eastbank (ED08):** riverside greenways, apartments, growing professional population.

West / Residential

- **Inboden (ED09):** older subdivided homes, mostly owner-occupied; hard school trips.
- **Quail Run (ED10):** townhomes, duplexes, too little childcare.

- **West Commons (ED11):** family apartments, new infill, crowded schools.
- **Cavanaugh (ED12):** apartments near transit; wage-only households.

East / Growth

- **Manila (ED13):** big mixed-use blocks, newer homes, growth outpacing infrastructure.
- **Schumaker (ED14):** working households near advanced logistics sites; long commutes.
- **Harback (ED15):** fringe settlements leaving wells and septic; annexation disputes.

North / Expansion

- **Prairie Crossing (ED16):** new housing, rising high school enrollment, transit expansion dispute.
- **Northfield (ED17):** new, mostly owner-occupied; uneven nearby services.
- **Box Elder (ED18):** flooding drainage crossings; many renters and seasonal workers.
- **Portside (ED19):** employment-district edge; shift work, airport noise.
- **High Prairie (ED20):** high-income large-lot housing that pays for its own infrastructure.

What residents are dealing with

These conditions are SCENARIO.

1. **Housing costs and instability.** Longtime owners and newer renters are far apart financially; South Yards and Colfax East have many renters and severe cost burdens. Emergency rent aid, tenant information, inclusionary housing and legal support are unsettled.
2. **Mismatched addresses and records.** Old farm addresses, new parcels and apartment complexes may not match across county GIS mapping, postal delivery, tax rolls, utility accounts and school assignment. An account does not prove residency.
3. **Water and land conversion.** Groundwater, farm parcels, special districts and utility extensions limit supply. Households, developers and industrial employers compete for service commitments.
4. **Long distances.** Much of the city-county is low-density. The center has a scenario rail hub; the north and east have infrequent service, late-shift workers and no settled transit partnership. The city cannot order the Regional Transportation District (RTD) to run a municipal route.
5. **Jobs without matching housing.** Logistics, manufacturing, entertainment, medical institutions, schools and services bring varied shifts, pay, noise and labor demand.
6. **Public authority and appeals.** In Colorado's real structure, the county administers state-supervised benefits. The city-county must decide how new city services connect to them without taking over state eligibility rules.
7. **Health and emergency access.** With a scenario trauma center, dispatch integration, patient information, 911, emergency access, public safety and hospital data are unsettled.
8. **Schools and young families.** Shifting enrollment, new attendance boundaries and school transportation create urgent demands. School districts are independent, so their participation must be negotiated.

9. **Growth on farmland and floodplains.** Farmland, drainage corridors and protected airspace are real constraints. Growth creates value for some and displacement risk for landowners, tenants, farmworkers and nearby communities.
10. **Participation and representation.** Neighborhoods differ in language access, income, tenure, commute and ability to attend evening meetings. A citywide digital vote or app may repeat those gaps.

Civic and cultural anchors

These institutions are SCENARIO; their funding, ownership, digital systems and service agreements are OPEN.

- The Hangar at Space Center: 17,500-seat arena at the central RTD rail hub. The hub's capital plan, fare rules, station management and shared services are open.
- Denver Fawns (WNBA): based at The Hangar.
- Colorado Apex (PWHL): plays at The Hangar.
- Denver Pilots (Triple-A baseball): moved from Albuquerque. They play at Aerotropolis Park, a 16,210-seat ballpark with views of launches from the fictional 2030 KCFO.
- East Detroit Philharmonic & Performing Arts Center (EDPAC): 2,200 seats. A proposed 1% Public Art Commercial Fee is a financing question, not adopted law.
- East Detroit Health System: Level I regional trauma center, aerospace flight medicine program and teaching hospital. Joining a government emergency data exchange is open.

The teams, relocations and launches are invented.

Public institutions you will work with

East Detroit has its own city and county departments, elected leaders and Fire Department. These bodies serve its residents but are independent:

- East Detroit Unified School District
- East Detroit Public Library District, which runs the libraries
- East Detroit Water and Sewer Authority
- Regional Transportation District (RTD), the real Denver-area transit authority
- the State of Colorado's human services and IT agencies (real)
- East Detroit County Court, funded by the city-county but independent in its decisions
- East Detroit Health and Hospital Authority, the public safety-net hospital
- East Detroit Health System, the trauma and teaching hospital
- East Detroit Regional Housing Authority (EDRHA), which runs federal housing assistance, also beyond the city

Airport operators, federal agencies and neighboring governments also constrain the city.

The City and County Housing Division (EDHD) handles city-funded housing policy, affordable housing development and preservation, local assistance and homelessness prevention. It works with EDRHA but cannot direct it (see Reading 3). The Directory of Departments and Agencies describes each body.

Six test households

Table 4. Invented case households for class exercises

Case	Household and situation	Question for agencies
H01	Two adults and one child renting in Colfax East; one hourly worker's schedule changes weekly	Can they complete and correct an application without taking time off work?
H02	Retired homeowner in Old Watkins; the parcel has an old rural address and an unmatched new GIS record	Which office owns the correction, and who keeps a pending request open?
H03	Three-generation household in Box Elder; Spanish is the preferred service language	What is available in person, by phone and in translation?
H04	Transit-dependent shift worker in Portside; the employer's private shuttle stops before the final shift ends	What happens if RTD or the employer declines a service partnership?
H05	Single parent in West Commons with two children entering different schools	Can city services coordinate without claiming control over an independent school district?
H06	Small business owner in South Yards whose address and parcel records do not match	Who decides whether a permit proceeds while county GIS corrects the source record?

Test every service against at least four kinds of case:

- a routine case
- a disputed record
- an outside partner that refuses to take part
- a case that needs human help or an appeal

You may add cases, change details and debate what they mean.

Sources

These real sources set the geographic and demographic scale. They do not describe East Detroit.

1. Adams County, *Colorado Air and Space Port Subarea Plan* (study-area map, p. 3; recommendations; utilities). https://adamscountyco.gov/wp-content/uploads/2025/08/space-port-subarea-plan.pdf
2. U.S. Census Bureau, QuickFacts: Adams County, Colorado (2020–2024 income, housing, race and rent; 2025 population). https://www.census.gov/quickfacts/fact/table/adamscountycolorado/PST045225

3. Census Reporter, Watkins CDP, Colorado (2020–2024 American Community Survey). https://censusreporter.org/profiles/16000US0882900-watkins-co/
4. Colorado Information Marketplace, DRCOG Municipal Boundaries (updated 2026). https://data.colorado.gov/Government/DRCOG-Municipal-Boundaries/xufp-56dv
5. Colorado Legislative Council, *Colorado Local Government Handbook* (city and county structure, school and special districts). https://content.leg.colorado.gov/sites/default/files/local_gov_hb_web.pdf